## Field Notes

# Field Note 1

## By Nairuti Vora

#### Interview 1: Cleo User

- **Target / Persona:** CS Undergraduate Student (Micro-savings user)
- **Competitor Evaluated:** Cleo (Direct Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown (onboarding & chat flow evaluation)

#### Notes & Observations (Tagged)

1. **[Behavior]** User regularly uses Cleo's micro-savings feature and completed the onboarding setup in under 3 minutes after linking their bank account.
2. **[Opinion]** User found the "roast" feature funny and engaging initially, but felt that the chat-bot novel effect wore off after a month.
3. **[Behavior]** When standing in line at a coffee shop, the user avoids opening the AI chat to ask "Can I afford this?" because it requires too many interaction steps.
4. **[Opinion]** User feels that asking a conversational chatbot for quick spending checks takes too much effort; they prefer an automatic, immediate display of their safe-to-spend limit.
5. **[Behavior]** Auto-save rules (round-ups) run silently in the background and are the primary feature the user continues to retain and rely on long-term.

#### Interview 2: Monarch Money User

- **Target / Persona:** Working Professional / Graduate Student

- **Competitor Evaluated:** Monarch Money (Direct / Adjacent Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown (budget allocation & analytics breakdown)

**Notes & Observations (Tagged)**

1. **[Behavior]** User regularly checks Monarch Money's visual charts and dashboards to review past monthly spending.
2. **[Opinion]** User loves the detail in Monarch's charts, but feels the system is completely backward-looking.
3. **[Behavior]** User typically notices overspending (e.g., on dining out) only at the end of the month after the spending has already occurred.
4. **[Opinion]** User believes the app fails to deliver real value because it does not proactively intervene or assist in adjusting budget categories mid-month.
5. **[Behavior]** User rarely interacts with Monarch's AI financial assistant because it is located deep within the settings menu.

## Field Note 2

## By Hector F Pariente

**Interview 1: Monarch Money User**

- **Target / Persona:** Graduate Student / Working Professional
- **Competitor Evaluated:** Monarch Money (Direct / Adjacent Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown

**Notes & Observations (Tagged)**

1. **[Behavior]** User relies primarily on main visual dashboards for financial tracking rather than using conversational AI features.

2. **[Opinion]** User feels that static reporting dashboards act like a "mirror" of past mistakes rather than an active tool for saving money.
3. **[Behavior]** User performs heavy manual setup at the start of each month to set strict monthly category budget caps.
4. **[Opinion]** User expressed frustration that when they go over budget in one category, the app does not suggest dynamic mid-month reallocations from other funds.
5. **[Behavior]** User did not utilize the AI query assistant due to low feature discovery during daily navigation.

#### Interview 2: YNAB (You Need A Budget) User

- **Target / Persona:** Former YNAB User (Churned due to complexity)
- **Competitor Evaluated:** YNAB (Indirect Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown (category assignment flow)

#### Notes & Observations (Tagged)

1. **[Behavior]** User abandoned YNAB after missing transaction logging for a week and becoming overwhelmed by the backlog.
2. **[Opinion]** User views manual category assignment and fixing miscategorized items as feeling like "homework".
3. **[Behavior]** User had to manually approve every transaction under YNAB's strict zero-based budgeting rules.
4. **[Opinion]** User felt the steep learning curve during the first 30 days created too much cognitive load and frustration.
5. **[Behavior]** User eventually stopped opening the app entirely, resulting in complete churn.

## Field Note 3

## By  Francisco X Vazquez

#### Interview 1: Cleo User

- **Target / Persona:** CS Undergraduate Student
- **Competitor Evaluated:** Cleo (Direct Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown

#### Notes & Observations (Tagged)

1. **[Behavior]** User signed up for Cleo to manage micro-savings and test out its AI conversational interface.
2. **[Opinion]** User thinks the conversational "roasts" and chat engagement are entertaining at first, but become gimmicky over time.
3. **[Behavior]** User bypasses the chat interface when making fast-paced, real-time purchasing decisions in store settings.
4. **[Opinion]** User believes conversational AI adds unnecessary friction when all they need is a quick visual status check.
5. **[Behavior]** User maintains active engagement only with automated background auto-save rules.

#### Interview 2: YNAB (You Need A Budget) User

- **Target / Persona:** College Student / Former Manual Budgeter
- **Competitor Evaluated:** YNAB (Indirect Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown

#### Notes & Observations (Tagged)

1. **[Behavior]** User attempted to maintain strict manual zero-based budgeting to control daily spending.

2. **[Opinion]** User felt that manually sorting every single unallocated dollar was exhausting and unsustainable.
3. **[Behavior]** User accumulated multiple unassigned transactions after missing logging for several consecutive days.
4. **[Opinion]** User believes that without automated AI sorting, budgeting tools demand too much time and energy.
5. **[Behavior]** User quit using the application due to high maintenance overhead.

## Field Note 4

## By  Kinley Tenzin

#### Interview 1: Monarch Money User

- **Target / Persona:** Working Professional / Graduate Student
- **Competitor Evaluated:** Monarch Money (Direct / Adjacent Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown

#### Notes & Observations (Tagged)

1. **[Behavior]** User paid for Monarch Money to track overall net worth and aggregate household financial accounts.
2. **[Opinion]** User feels that despite detailed charts, the app fails to prevent overspending before it occurs.
3. **[Behavior]** User manually reviews past expenses at the end of the monthly cycle.
4. **[Opinion]** User thinks budgeting tools should proactively alert and help adjust remaining category caps mid-month.
5. **[Behavior]** User relies strictly on the visual interface rather than utilizing built-in AI assistant queries.

#### Interview 2: Cleo User

- **Target / Persona:** CS Undergraduate Student
- **Competitor Evaluated:** Cleo (Direct Competitor)
- **Duration & Setup:** 15-minute interview + 30-minute teardown

**Notes & Observations (Tagged)**

1. **[Behavior]** User engaged frequently with Cleo's automated prompt notifications during the initial weeks of installation.
2. **[Opinion]** User reported that having to type messages in a chat interface creates friction during fast transactions.
3. **[Behavior]** User relies heavily on background micro-saving rules to build emergency savings.
4. **[Opinion]** User wishes the app provided a clear visual dashboard card for instantaneous "safe-to-spend" checking rather than requiring a chat query.
5. **[Behavior]** User stopped using the conversational agent for daily expenditure checks, retaining only passive features.